



Microsoft's new 'fund'

Microsoft is striving to bring affordable internet for all by launching a new fund to achieve this goal. <http://dgit.in/MicrosoftFund>



Yes, I'm safe

Amid mixed reactions about the feature, Facebook reportedly is planning to continue its efforts <http://dgit.in/FBSafetyChk>

Work@tech

WHY VFX IS EXCITING TODAY

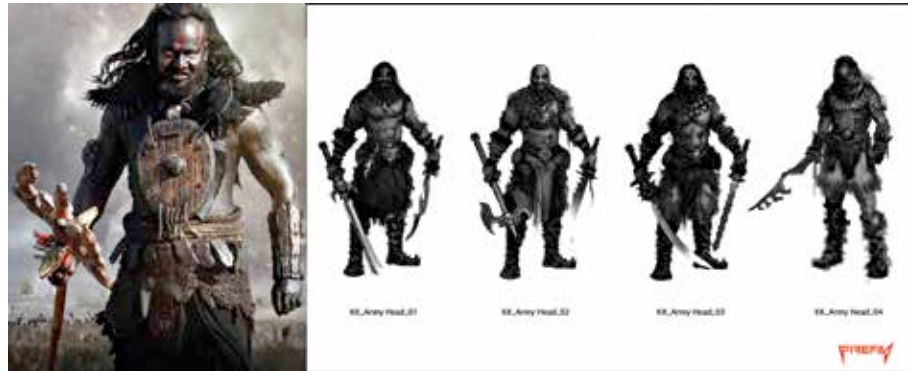
The sheer number of studios in India now along with the increased collaborations among them has made this industry an undeniable breeding ground for aspiring VFX artists. Suresh Eriyat - Founder and Creative Director, Eeksaurus says, "VFX has the potential to create huge employment opportunities, however, that is subject to collaboration and close co-operation between the VFX entities of India. If they stand alone and compete against each other, the industry's growth will be stunted. In Bahubali, I'm told that 17 VFX companies worked together. Such collaboration is a welcome trend for the industry as a whole."

TV networks, production houses and ad makers are sitting up and taking notice of this development – both abroad as well as locally – and teaming up with special effects companies in India to reap the additional benefit of cost cutting. Danny suggests yet another advantage of this collaboration: "More people can get involved at the independent level as well to get more creativity so it doesn't get bogged down to the big studios only, in turn encouraging a bit more out-of-the-box thinking, making it an exciting time to be in the VFX industry."

BRIGHT FUTURE, HERE I COME! OH WAIT...

"No VFX artists were harmed in the making of this film" should ideally appear at the end of film or television credits. We don't mean to scare you, but there are some challenges working in VFX. This industry is only for the strong-willed hard workers who persevere under tough conditions such as long hours and lack of projects.

E. Suresh of Eeksaurus advises you to expect a 10-hour day during the normal in-flow of work and around 15 hours a day during peak work season. "Work, when it comes, would seem like a never-ending story. This coupled with multiple changes from clients keeps every professional on their toes." If you love what you do however, time flies. Also, remember, you'll be surrounded by talented artists, innovators and veterans from the industry along-



Concept art by Firefly for the Kalakeyas

side whom you'll be working, so you can expect to learn more than just the basics (read: things you won't learn in a training institute ordinarily).

Another necessity for a successful career in special FX is the right kind of employee. If a company hasn't done its due diligence, it may suffer or end up shutting down and you'll be left with nowhere to go. Look at Rhythm and Hues that was forced to shut down after its thumping success at the Oscars for Life of Pi. Danny states, "You don't want to work with a company that gets too big too fast. There are VFX studios that have a strong start but they don't have the longevity to continue, to be able to foresee the next thing that happens ('Now this is happening, so the next thing has to be this' kind of thought process). So if a studio is letting go of employees or not paying their employees, it's because the work isn't there. The work is out there. You have to get your people to get the work into your studio. The key to a successful VFX studio is to have a strong clientele, a strong marketing backbone. The more VFX studios bring in international clientele, the better

the exposure for these artists to grow and flourish and become something more."

Suresh Eriyat advocates working with studios that collaborate with each other (like the studios involved in the post production of Baahubali did), rather than ones that try to outdo each other and try to create their own VFX empire. So you have a level of security knowing you have growth in the future.

WHAT KIND OF MONEY TO EXPECT

As a fresher, you can expect to earn around ₹15,000-20,000 and once you gain adequate experience, anything from a lakh to a couple of lakhs and more is yours for the asking. And if you can't decide whether to take on freelance projects or a full-time job, remember that freelancers are often paid more since they work on contract-based jobs, however, the amount of pay they rake in is undoubtedly based on their level of talent and experience. There's a caveat though. As a freelancer in the VFX industry, as with any field, there's no stability.

WHERE TO STUDY

There are different ways to get into the VFX industry and not all of them require an education. However, one criteria in common with recruiting departments across the board - a set of skills, which includes technical problem solving skills, a good eye for detail, creative bent of mind, basic drawing skills (so a background in Fine Art would be great, although not necessary), a solid understanding of photography and the interplay of light, color and shadow.



Suresh Eriyat, Founder and Creative Director of Eeksaurus